

From reality to dream

Among the various virtualisation software mentioned in this Fast Track, we spoke briefly about the Parallels Workstation and its unique ability of taking your current live system and packing it up as a virtual hard disk in the Parallel's native format so that it will work with the Parallels Workstation (and other products from the company). This can be immensely useful for making sure that whatever you have on your system is available to you in a portable format. It also helps you to take your system and convert it to a virtual machine which your friend might need (porting an environment). However, that feature doesn't work on every OS and takes up so much space on an external drive (if that's the method you choose) or time when transferring over the network. This isn't what you'll want to do very often but it can be a life-saver at times. If you're a Linux enthusiast, this method is similar to using the `dd` command to map up your whole hard disk into a removable media while running a live system. You could also pipe the output through a compression program to make the size smaller. 